could take the best part of a year to sail from Sydney to London. This ‘tyranny of distance’ was eventually overcome in the mid-19th century by steam navigation and communication improvements made possible by the electric cable telegraph. But the vast distance from Europe made it imperative that Australians find suitable products to ship to Europe in exchange for the manufactured products of Britain’s Industrial Revolution. Before the 1820s, whaling and sealing were prosperous maritime trades in Australian waters. By the 1840s, both trades had declined permanently due to new laws enacted by the government.

The rapid growth of the pastoral frontier in New South Wales and Australia Felix between 1820 and 1850 led to a surge in wool exports, which comprised over two-thirds of colonial Australia’s total export income by 1850. Wool remained the leading export from Australia to the mother country for generations apart from gold, which surpassed it after 1851 for two decades. The introduction of the wool press revolutionized the industry by reducing the weight of wool carried by three-quarters. Furthermore, the gold rush of the 1850s produced an important mineral for export. In the 1880s, Australian ships also exported wheat, refrigerated meat and dairy products to Britain. Coal was exported from Australia but it was not until the late 1930s that bulk carriers were built in Australia to carry coal overseas. By the 1960s, Australia’s industrialization had enabled a ‘seaport industrial machine’ to integrate the raw materials and metallurgical industry with bulk carriers.

Australian trade with the wider world was not only confined to long-distance connections with Britain. Sandalwood was exported to China in the 19th century. Tahitian pork was imported from various areas for consumption in Australian homes. Tea, sugar and rice were commodities that linked Asia with Australia. On the eve of the First World War, France bought more than half of Australia’s wool and hides while Belgium and Germany took most of the zinc and almost half of the copper. Nevertheless, Anglo-Australian commodity trade was still dominant with 60% of Australia’s import income coming from the United Kingdom and 44% of Australia’s exports being sent to the UK in 1913.